

Bizjets and Turboprop Rivals

In the 1980s business aircraft really came into their own, with literally dozens of different designs on the market, powered by both jet and turboprop engines. Aircraft such as Beechcraft's King Air series filled a variety of niches within both the military and civil sectors, while air freight companies offering an "overnight service" (such as FedEx) bought the single engine Caravan by the hundreds.



△ Bae Jetstream 31 1980 (Jetstream)

Origin UK
Engine 2 x 940hp Garrett TPE331 turboprop
Top speed 303mph (488 km/h)

Although early model Jetstreams were powered by Turbomecca turboprops, the 31 was fitted with more powerful Garrett engines. These had the option of water-methanol injection, which greatly improved performance in "hot-and-high" operations. The aircraft sold well, particularly in the US.



△ Mitsubishi Diamond/Hawker Beechjet 400A 1980

Origin Japan/USA
Engine 2 x 2,950lb (1,336 kg) thrust Pratt & Whitney Canada JT15D turbofan
Top speed 539mph (866 km/h)

Originally known as the Mitsubishi Mu-300 Diamond, it was renamed the Beechjet 400 when Beech bought the rights, and then the Hawker 400 when Beech acquired Hawker. Popular with private owners, air-taxi operators, and charter outfits, the USAF also operates around 180 as trainers, called the T.1 Jayhawk.



◁ Dassault Falcon 200 1980

Origin France
Engine 2 x 5,440lb (2,464 kg) thrust Garrett ATF-3 turbofan
Top speed 536mph (862 km/h)

Originally called the Dassault-Breguet Mystère 20, this aircraft was known as the Fan Jet Falcon in the US, and then Falcon 20. The 200 was the final version and incorporated a number of improvements, including more powerful engines. Around 500 Falcons in the 20/200 series were built between 1965 and 1988. The US Coast Guard operates the type as the HU-25 Guardian.



▽ Cessna 421C Golden Eagle 1981

Origin USA
Engine 2 x 375hp Continental GTSIO-520 air-cooled flat-6
Top speed 295mph (475 km/h)

Derived from the earlier Cessna 411 (it shares the same Type Certificate), the principal difference is that the Golden Eagle is pressurized. Popular with small commuter airlines, and also with private owners, more than 1,900 were built before production ceased in 1985.



▷ Cessna 208B Grand Caravan 1984

Origin USA
Engine 677hp Pratt & Whitney Canada PT6A turboprop
Top speed 197mph (317 km/h)

An extremely successful aircraft, the Caravan is operated by dozens of air forces, government agencies, and civilian operators all over the world. It can be flown on wheels, skis, or floats, and in a multitude of roles, including short-haul feederliner, freighter, air ambulance, and as a parachute drop plane.

